

¹As for the former factor, ‘voiceless’ flaps could be seen as a direct result of Thomas’s (1958: 157–58) advice against ‘both the careless extreme ... [‘sɪdɪŋ], and the pedantic exaggeration ... [‘sɪtʰɪŋ]’. Note that the [d] actually seems to stand for a flap (cf. p. 48).

in material comparable to the transcribed speeches just discussed). However, as Kahn (1980a: 181) has noted, ‘voiceless’ flaps are fairly popular ‘among U. S. radio and television announcers [men, too, according to my observations], who are undoubtedly taught’, Kahn suggests, ‘that it is wrong to pronounce words such as *latter* and *ladder* alike’. Whether or not this suggestion is literally true (in every case), there might well be a connection here to the elocutionary tradition and to the old British-influenced elites’ nonflapping.¹

Of course, the tendency to use ‘voiceless’ flaps in the reading of news reports and other such material is probably reinforced by the distinction between ⟨t(t)⟩ and ⟨d(d)⟩ that is seen in the orthographic forms. As I will speculate in chapters 4 and 5, direct influence from the orthography may also have resulted in their frequent occurrence in phonetic experiments (making the data unrepresentative of ordinary speech). However, ‘voiceless’ flaps are by no means confined to read speech (though they could still be due, ultimately, to the orthographic forms); and so they might well have been used by the *LAUM* and Johnson informants, particularly—perhaps—by the groups who flapped the least according to the percentages reported.

In summary, it cannot be denied that there has been a spread of flapping in American English during the twentieth century. But the lenition would actually seem to have been almost as common in the 1930s, at least, as it is today—when we consider purely intervocalic forms of the word-medial post-stressed and word-final (weak-boundary) contexts (though the word-initial cases in function words such as *to* and *did* could probably be included), and casual, everyday styles of speech. Accordingly, the gains have presumably involved, on the one hand, new contexts: the inter-unstressed context, and some of the non-intervocalic ones (primarily the *thirty* and *kettle* types, perhaps). On the other hand, flapping has spread to more prestigious accents and to more controlled styles. The careful speech of certain elite groups may earlier have been almost free from flapping; and other speakers too might have showed a stronger tendency to avoid flapping in very controlled styles than do comparable speakers today. The gains in these respects, though, may have been partly a matter of ‘voiceless’ flaps—which now seem rare—being replaced with ordinary voiced ones. These conclusions are very tentative, of course; I cannot possibly claim to have pieced together a satisfactory recent history of American English flapping. (Even among the inadequate data that we have considered, the ones in the *LAUM* [Allen 1976] and in Johnson 1978, for example, show opposite social stratifications which remain to be explained.)